

Harlem Renaissance

A cultural explosion took place during the 1920s and 1930s among black Americans living in America. Inspired by their African heritage, they explored music, dance, film, painting, theatre and cabaret, incorporating jazz and blues music, and colourful, expressive painting.

Even after the American Civil War had ended in 1865, southern states did not give liberated black slaves the vote and most amenities were segregated by race. As industrialization created job opportunities in the north, some 2 million African Americans migrated from 1910 to 1930, settling in cities such as Chicago, Philadelphia, Cleveland and New York. After years of oppression, they began conveying a new-found optimism in many ways. The Harlem district of New York City in particular attracted a number of talented individuals, and became symbolic capital of a wider art movement whose members included Aaron Douglas (1898–1979), William H. Johnson (1901–70), Lois Mailou Jones (1905–98), Sargent Claude Johnson (1888–1967) and Charles Alston (1907–77).



Jacob Lawrence, *The Migration Series*, Panel No. 1, 1940–41